

Make a **SCENE** for Yourself

Movie making is no longer just a Bollywood business. You don't need professional tools to make magic, just a basic multimedia PC

Movies are probably the most engrossing and popular of all communications and entertainment media. A well made movie is one that enchants all the five senses, suspending reality for a brief period of time. Remember how your heart skipped a beat when the T-Rex thumped onto the screen in *Jurassic Park*? Or the prickly feeling you got while watching *Evil Dead*? The numbness you experienced when the girl screamed away in *The Blair Witch Project*? Once the domain of a handful of professionals, advances in computing have evolved to such an extent that almost anyone can now make videos on their desktop.

The toughest hurdles in making movies have always been the expensive equipment and complicated software involved. We don't need either for making personal videos. With low-end digital video (DV) cameras and Web cams becoming very affordable, making movies is a hobby that can now be enjoyed by almost anyone. Software too is very abundant and easily available. So all you need to do is plug in the camera, install the software and shoot away to your first video. Home video no longer needs to be shaky with poor picture quality—very powerful tools help create the perfect picture and add a lot of cool effects. Transitions, fade effects, sound effects, freeze-frames—all these and more are possible with basic tools.

The biggest advantage that digital video has over the old analogue way is the introduction of non-linear editing—you can cut, copy, paste, delete, add

and merge chunks of video just as you would edit a Word document. Also, you don't need to manage piles of video tape. You can preview the video as you capture it and re-take it as many times as you want without worrying about wasting reels of film. Mixing and matching the good parts of all the clips is a breeze.

Your baby boy's first steps or your daughter's third birthday—you can capture these precious moments, burn them onto CDs and cherish them forever, without worrying about dust, fungus, or moisture damaging the video. You can even use video for making presentations and sales pitches—a concept video will certainly make a bigger impact than a slideshow of projection graphs.

Filmy fundas

Knowing the basics of digital video is the key to creating smooth, error-free and good quality movies. Here are some things you should keep in mind.

Resolution: Resolution not only determines the height and width of the movie, it also directly affects the movie quality and the file size. Also, at higher frame sizes, more processing power is used, so if the video seems jerky, you should lower this setting. Generally 320x240 is good enough, but you may want to capture at 640x480 if your system allows it.

Frame rate: The frame rate determines the number of frames that make up one second of the video. Thus, higher frame rates mean a better quality video. The human eye perceives smooth motion at a minimum rate of 24 frames per second, so a frame rate of 30 is ideal—it will look smooth and allow for a few dropped frames.

